

ergies with ISRO, including utilising the agency's facilities for use by the private sector. He explains that within the MoU IN-SPACe has signed with ISRO, "We have a Joint Project Implementation Plan (JPIP) that will be an agreement between ISRO and the private entities for certain activities". Goenka says that IN-SPACe will facilitate the drafting of the JPIP as well as address "any roadblocks that may arise".

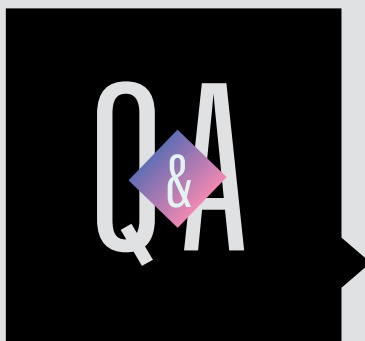
"We are confident that in a few years, you will find the whole landscape changing, where the suppliers will become capable of designing and operating space systems on a commercial scale," says Somanath.

SOARING AMBITIONS

Following Skyroot's success, the ambitions of several other spacetechn start-ups have soared. These companies are developing everything from launch vehicles to satellites to space applications.

Another positive is that the global perception about Indian spacetechn start-ups is changing. "India always had a good reputation concerning space, but it was limited to ISRO. What has changed now is that people are confident that other companies will also be able to deliver because India already has that expertise," says Awais Ahmed, CEO & Co-founder of hyperspectral satellite maker Pixxel. Founder & CTO Kshitij Khandelwal adds that there is a willingness on the part of the government and ISRO to not only work with private players but also look at them as operators in the ecosystem.

Recently, Chennai-based launch vehicle maker AgniKul Cosmos unveiled the country's first-ever private launchpad at SDSC that has been executed with the support of ISRO and IN-SPACe. AgniKul Co-founder & CEO Srinath Ravichandran says it's a dream come true for



'INDIA MAY HAVE ITS FIRST SPACETECH UNICORN IN 2023'

IN-SPACe Chairperson Pawan Goenka says big investors are ready to listen to Indian start-ups in the space sector and fund them

BY MANISH PANT

Now that a few spacetechn start-ups have had major demonstrable successes, how much ground has been covered by IN-SPACe in the two years since it was founded?

Since the full team at IN-SPACe started operating only in April 2022, we have practically been active for eight months. And a lot has been achieved in that timeframe. We have facilitated requests for authorisation, handholding and the use of ISRO facilities or tech transfers [that we] received from the private sector.

How many proposals have you received till this point?

So far, we have received 160 such proposals. Almost half of them are start-ups and the rest are established companies. Among these, five were authorised for space ac-

tivities. AgniKul's pre-orbital launch is also in the pipeline. There are a couple of more companies working on launch vehicles. We hope that satellite manufacturing—both for use within and outside India—would become a fairly large activity. IN-SPACe is working on incentivising the private sector to work with ISRO in the area of applications in a big way. We would also like the private sector to enter the ground segment.

Do you see further improvement in funding for Indian spacetechn start-ups among investors?

Some large funds have shown interest. A good space start-up with a solid story won't find it difficult to get funding as we have reached a point where investors are willing to listen to them.